

# A COLLECTION OF LIFE STORIES | Lou Ellen Ehnis





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# What was your first big trip?



Our first and last big trip was a safari in Kenya in the fall of 1997.

At my last board meeting before retiring from the Area Agency on Aging of Northwest Michigan, a board member asked the usual question....what are your retirement plans. To travel of course. He and his wife were going on a group trip to Africa and invited us to join. Why not!

So we got passports and all the necessary shots. And six months later were on our way. Metro to Amsterdam to Nairobi. Long trip, return trip even longer.

Never having traveled out of the country, we were surprised at all the machine gun toting guards in the terminal. On to buses to the very modern hotel. After getting settled in rooms we attended "orientation to Africa meetings". Even after all the

warnings many were stupid tourists. One woman and her adult daughter were accosted going unescorted just a block or so to a market. We took a side trip into town with others. While in a jewelry store I was told to remove a small gold chain I forgot I was wearing, because I never took it off, before we left the store or someone would probably grab it.

The traffic in Nairobi was crazy, as it apparently is in many foreign countries, no stop signs or lights. Everyone for himself, just honk your horn and be aggressive. Didn't seem to be many accidents though. Buses were many and overloaded...always room for one more no matter how much they were carrying.

Once we were away from the city it was very different. A long way between anything. Roads were rarely paved or marked. Towns were a just few buildings. People ran everywhere, barefoot. There were periodically tourist traps you were expected to buy at. They would ship for you! You were told to be careful not to wander across a border or you could be arrested.

It was really great once you were where the animals were. Every kind of African animal you could imagine. Mostly they didn't pay any attention to us as long as we weren't a threat. But the guides were all armed and watchful. Hippos were the most skittish and move really fast . Elephants and lions were the most casual. Giraffes were the friendliest. We visited a place you could touch



and feed them. They are very drooling.

Accommodations were varied. One “hotel” was in tree tops. Fun. Out in the open so there were armed guards between vehicles and the trees. One was huts with mosquito netting over the beds and a main building with guards to escort you to your hut because animals wandered in. One was a really nice normal (1997) place.

At that one were at a really high elevation and Grandpa was just at the beginning of his failing health and we weren’t really aware of it. We went on an excursion with everyone else in small boats across a river and were able to walk around with the animals. Grandpa was not doing well, short of breath and slow. We almost didn’t get back to the last boat. It was really scary for us and the others.

At one place called the Carnivore or something like that, we sat at long tables and they brought around platters of all kind of wild animal meat and local foods.

All in all it was a great trip. New and interesting places its hard to imagine from a country such as ours. I’m sure I’ve forgotten a lot of interesting tidbits. But a really great trip.

At the Amsterdam airport on the way home we had a long layover so we, of course, played a few slots in the terminal. Grandpa won a little. The return trip took a good 24 hours . We

were whipped when we got home but it was a great trip..

# What is the best meal you've ever had?



**Y**our question was what my first boss was like.

That could be answered in one sentence. He was a lecherous male chauvinist pig. I was spared because I was naive, and not the kind of woman he was interested in. Pretty and knowledgeable and was available but not interested in him. Job didn't last long. We both moved on.

My working life was short before real life began. The 54 years difference in our ages really shows how different life was when I was young. Times were changing, women were just beginning to become working women as you know them and not just "Rosie the riveter" or secretarial kind of jobs.

However, Grandpa was old fashioned too and grew up thinking he should be the provider and didn't want me to work anyway. I did work for a couple years with really great bosses. One of which was a woman. They were all great.

I changed the question because I didn't think I had more than one sentence to contribute....wrong again.

So I changed the question and then got vocal so you get a twofer.



The best, most memorable meal was the week before we got married. Have no idea what we had though. We had rented the first floor of a duplex at 934 Dewey Street and spent the whole day cleaning and moving furniture in. We were pooped and dirty, and didn't have any foodstuff yet anyway so we went to the Old German. At that time it was downtown west of Main street.

It was probably just a job well done and excitement of coming changes but we never forgot how good the meal was.

# What were your favorite toys as a child?



I don't recall having a lot of toys. I had some dolls. There were a few baby dolls including one called Betsy Wetsy that you could give a bottle of water and she would wet her diaper. (Exciting huh). A Raggedy Ann. A small 6" one called Arabella given to me by a boarder (Sue Bailor) we had living with us. It had been hers when she was a child. And the favorite was one similar to the current American Girl doll. Can't recall her name. My mother was a good seamstress and made a lot of my clothes and would make matching outfits for the doll. There's a picture of me holding my doll, I'll try to find and insert, standing on the stairs in matching outfits. Most of the dolls are upstairs in a box.

My childless aunt and uncle always gave us good gifts for Christmas, mostly games like the Sorry one I still have and you've probably played because it remains one of my favorites. The only other one that really sticks out, and is in a box

somewhere, is a metal girl ice skater. I'm sure you've probably seen this too. Maybe 5 or 6" tall. Has a metal rod you insert then pull out and she twirls for a while.

Life was simpler back then. My mother always enjoyed giving little kids a pot and a wooden spoon. Noisy but keeps them amused.



Me with my matching doll

# Are you still friends with any of your friends from high school? How have they changed since then?



Only two and rarely have contact with them. Uncle Bill talked to them recently and at 90 and 91 they're doing ok. Marlene has had several joint replacements and is wheelchair bound. Lyle is well. Survived bone cancer in his legs many years ago. Their 3 daughters are all retired. Marlene had 3 sisters. The two youngest have been gone for many years. The remaining one is widowed and blind.

Uncle Bill is only other person I know from school. He may know one or two but doesn't have much contact either.

I think I pretty much lost contact by 10 years out. By then people had gone to college and moved on or just got a life.

Grandpa was different. They had class reunions every 5 years up to at least the year before he died. That's 50 years. And football reunions too. Ann Arbor was apparently much closer knit community and less "class" conscience.



# What is one of your favorite children's stories?



I don't know that I have a favorite story. I used to have a large, fat red book of fairy tales and other stories. Always liked Rapunzel.

And had a great little yellow book that would now not be politically correct or even allowed. It was called Little Black Sambo. It was delightful and not demeaning at all. Just a fun little black boy. Probably taught me people are just people. Obviously impressed me to think of it 80+ years later.

I also really enjoyed reading Shel Silverstein's "Where the Sidewalk Ends" to Zac and Alex when they stayed with us. I gave it to them when I moved. It remains Alex's favorite.



# What was your Mom like when you were a child?



**T**his is a hard one. It's been a long time since I was a child. I've been through being a mother and grandmother so might confuse fact with fiction. Remember how long ago I was a child and how times have changed. Your relationship with your grandparents is much different than mine was.

My mother became a mother at not quite 21 but had four younger brothers so she had some experience with handling young people and probably was not as intimidated as many young mothers as a caretaker, but she didn't really learn parenting.

Her parents had lost an infant daughter and a 20something son which probably influenced my mother to some degree and made her more aware of how easily things could go wrong and consequently more protective of her own children.

However, I remember her being a caring mother even though being told we were loved was never voiced, but never expected either. We just were a family. There was a mom and dad and kids. You made sure they were taken care of, they grew up. Boys were more valued than girls. Maybe a carryover from the farm life when boys were helping hands. Girls were more household help.

She always took good care of us. Made most of my clothes and matching clothes for my doll. Always made sure we had everything we needed. She was stern and protective, sure her way was the BEST and ONLY way.

Always a presence in everything I did.

She was a girl scout leader, involved at school, became a cafeteria worker and cook at school, was friends with teachers. Always there to make sure we were treated fairly.

But never gave any real life advice or guidance. Nothing personal was ever discussed or life skills taught. That's the reason you took the manners class. I wanted you to be comfortable, learn the things I didn't and not doubt yourself.

All in all she was a caring mother, looking after her children the best she knew how. We seem to have turned out ok so I guess she did her job.





# Where did you go on vacations as a child?



Vacations were always fun. It was always camping.

We had a 1931 Model A Ford with a trunk on the back.

My mother would fill the leg space behind the front seats with stuff, cover it with bedding. We'd get up EARLY in the morning (probably 4am), but, we could crawl in the car and go back to sleep. Nice.

I'm sure we went other places but the only specific place I remember was Tawas City state park (I think). Dad had friends in the area. Sometimes met church friends there. Great times.

Remember this was 80 years ago. Clean, uncrowded campgrounds. We had a 8 or 10 foot square umbrella tent. (Grandpa and I actually took it on our first vacation and amused the other campers trying to put it up. His only experience with tenting was in Korea. Much different from family camping. Famous last words ..I'm never sleeping in a tent again. Ha! and

he enjoyed it)

The trip itself was always an adventure because Dad saw everything along the way. All the wildlife, stars, whatever. He knew what all the road markings along the way meant. We even saw cows and other animals! So the trip itself was fun and educational. A lot simpler and more interesting than a trip along the highway today.

I always thought traveling at night was the best thing ever until I grew up. But by then roads had improved, traffic was heavier. And life became get from here to there as fast as you can.

Even a trip to Portage Lake from Dearborn through Ann Arbor where there was a dairy to get an ice cream cone, the pink kind with mint, at the corner of Washtenaw and Stadium (?), under the bridge you had to honk your horn under in Dexter (?). That was exciting stuff.

At Portage there were two towers to dive off, one higher than the other. In the building was a penny (maybe a nickel or quarter) machine with boxers inside. Didn't always get to play it. We'd already spent money on gas, can't do everything.

Can't remember anything else til the trip out west I already told you about.







# How did you rebel as a child?



**I** was a brat.



## Were you involved in any organizations in high school?



Not really. I'm not a "joiner". The only group I belonged to was older girl scouts called Mariners, who learned about boating and tying knots. I've never been political or strongly in favor of, or against, anything enough to do more than complain. Probably traces back to upbringing and not being encouraged to have an opinion, just do as you're told.



# What were your grandparents like?



William Frederick and Cora Belle Jones were my mothers parents. They were really nice people, but far different from your grandparents and way farther different from what Xander's will be.

They had nine kids in all. Seven boys and two girls. They lost the second son, Ray, in his twenties in a plane crash. He was practicing to be a stunt pilot. I have the article from the newspaper telling of it.

Twila died of some illness before she was a year old.

My mother, who wasn't born at the time, said it turned Grandpa into an angry, bitter man, mad at God and the church and doctors. I don't remember the whole story or how she knew it as she was the 5th child. He softened some later.

My brother was the first grandchild on both sides and I the third. There were eventually 9 plus some step and a couple adopted. So

no one was special. My youngest uncle was only seven and a half years older than Uncle Bill and many years younger than his older siblings. As an elderly man he told me he didn't really know much about his brothers because they were out of the house when he was quite young.

Grandma and Grandpa loved us all though. They moved a lot. Don't know if they ever owned a house. I remember one house on Park Street in Dearborn that had a blackberry tree in the yard. We of course got to pick and enjoy. Good stuff. Another special treat there was heavily buttered bread with brown sugar on it.

Another house on Burns street had a kid across the road with a pony we never got to ride. In that house they took in a boarder who had cancer, smelled bad and eventually died. So they were good people doing what they could for less fortunate people.

One time grandpa gave us three oldest girls matching bikes for no good reason except he wanted too.

Grandma was just(?) a mother and grandmother. Don't remember her doing anything else.

Grandpa was an excellent "body" man, could do wonderful things with metal. He did excellent work on cars and boats for the purple gang making secret hiding places for whatever they were smuggling or for weapons. Now I wonder if that's where they got the money to give their only daughter a nice wedding. Who knows. So ask questions before it's too late.



He lived to be a nice old man of 70something. Didn't like to visit for more than a few minutes though. They would come over and after 10 or 15 minutes it was time to leave.

Grandma lived to be 89 or 90.

There are many pictures of family picnics celebrating their birthdays or whatever so they were happy, social people.

William August and Edith Brockmiller were my father's parents. They, too, were nice people though Grandpa may have been an alcoholic. He drank Goebels beer. We kids loved it because at family get-togethers we got the last drops in everyone's bottles. It may also account for my dad not being a drinker though.

Grandpa was born in Germany and came over when he was a child. As adults, his parents, he and his two brothers all lived on the same block of Mason street in Dearborn. His father built several of the houses on that block. His mother lived in one of them til she died at about 90. His father was the hunchback who the special chair was built for. They eventually moved to 929 Monroe in an historic area. I have a book called "Lost Dearborn" that talks about and has pictures of the area. There was a fire station right next door with only the driveway between. Great amusement for grandkids.

He worked on the railroad until he lost his right arm, when my dad was a teenager, when it got caught between cars in ???. They brought him and his arm back to Dearborn on the train and

carried him and his arm to their house only a block away. There's a story about that you can find elsewhere. I've never been able to have sympathy for people who whine about that kind of loss because he could do almost everything except drive a car.

He worked at Ford Motor as an elevator operator after that. Had a really nice rose garden behind the garage.

Grandma was severe. Straight as an arrow, don't color outside the lines, do it right the first time, kind of person. A really good cook. Excellent lemon meringue and apple pie maker. But not a "come sit on my lap and tell me about it" person.

Don't know much about her early life except she was out of the house, working in a hotel when she was 13. I or, maybe your mother, have some glasses she saved from there.

Probably accounts for how severe she was.

We weren't as close to them as to the Jones'. Probably the mother/mother thing because my cousins have a different memory of loving grandparents.

My dad had two sisters. One never had children. The other had three who were much closer to their grandparents than we. The first four of us were all within 5 years. Clark was 5 or 6 years younger than Evelyn and paid for it!

I guess my memory of all of them is that they were just nice older people who put up with us. Nothing fun or personal. Just

family.

It all goes back to how different working families were back then.



Grandma Jones - Mom - Grandpa Jones

Uncles Harold, Cliff, Don, Melvin, Merle



# What are your favorite songs?



I'm struggling with this. I like a wide variety of music, different genres. I suppose songs from the forties and fifties with words you can actually understand. Frank Sinatra because he came into being when I was in the 8th grade. But I also like classic rock.

I go through different actual favorites periodically and then wonder why I liked it so much. So I'm not going to be specific today. Maybe I'll come back with a better answer another day.



## How did you celebrate your 30th birthday?

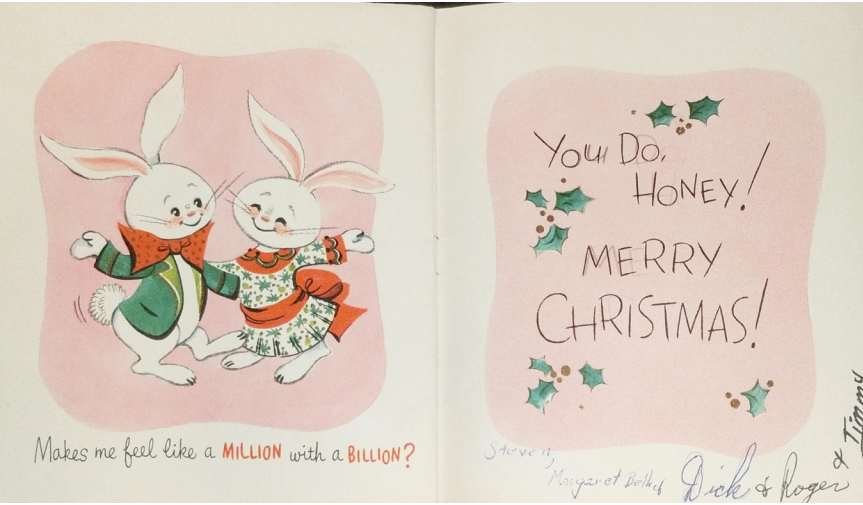


**L**ast week you asked for my favorite songs. One was “Long Ago and Far Away”. That’s what my 30th birthday is.

I can only make a guess. There have been a great many since then. Most celebrated in a similar manner.

Grandpa would have brought me a dozen red roses and a nice gift, probably went out for dinner. With an almost 4 year old and a 5 month old (your mom, same as Xander is now) I can’t believe we did much more.

If there was a card I probably still have it. Don’t know when we started it but after a few years of buying cards that said the same thing we just reused them. We each have a stack for every occasion. Some will be fun for you to look at eventually.



A reused Christmas card



# What beliefs do you have that are different than your parents?



Well, you've picked another difficult question. I've thought about it all week and still don't have a definitive answer.

I think it goes back to a different, simpler kind of life a long time ago. Or maybe our family didn't talk about or share thoughts. They were parents, we were kids. I really don't know their beliefs on anything other than morals and mine are pretty much like theirs. They taught us what they believed to be right and wrong.

Their religious beliefs seemed to be opposite. Mom was always involved with the Methodist church and went every Sunday taking us and involving us. Dad was raised Evangelical. His sisters stayed involved, he didn't. Don't know why but he never went to church with us. Made Sunday dinner instead. Yet when he was dying and was miserable we asked him what he wanted,

he just pointed up. So there must have been some belief. Maybe he just didn't believe in organized religion. So I guess I believe differently than them in that respect.

I'm sure we were much more flexible in discipline. There was no room for negotiations with them. What they said was the only way. I hope we were more flexible but then our kids might see it differently and think we were just as controlling.

I'm sure a lot of how they thought, did things and believed was determined by the times.

Manners, how you dressed and things like that just evolved. And are still evolving. Basically nothing really changed very much. We just do what we think is best for our families and the world as it is today.

# What is one of the most memorable camping trips you've been on?



**T**his is a good one! I have to build up to it as there are so many from early tenting to motor homing.

There were many camping trips growing up, but can't recall any well enough. Getting there was more interesting for me because Dad knew and told us all kinds of interesting stuff along the way. The very first camping trip Grampa and I took was unforgettable because we were so dumb. After living in tents in Korea for a year or so, Grandpa said he was never going to stay in a tent again. NEVER SAY NEVER! We took my parents umbrella tent, which I'd stayed in many times but never helped put up. Don't know where we went but it was a well populated campground not too far away. Thought we knew how to set it up. Easy right? Stake out four corners, push up center pole. It took us a good while to accomplish it as others just watched and laughed.

Later, when we had Steve, we went to Burt Lake with a 2 room tent, again from my folks. We had gotten better at putting tents up by then. Grandpa did like his beer and it was vacation so he consumed. In the middle of the night he needed to go but it's dark and the facilities were aways away. Of course he was beyond full so I told him to use the removable pot from the potty chair. Good idea til he filled in and had more to go and couldn't stop. Hilarity abounded as he made it out of the tent without dumping the pot.

Another time with our own new umbrella tent from Montgomery Wards we went somewhere near Holland. Nice sandy, near water. We had Steve and your mother (about a year old). I forgot the refrigerated food. Then a tornado went through nearby so we had a storm with really high winds. The windows were poorly designed with pockets under the window on the inside so the rain came in, collected in the pockets and dumped inside. Wards wouldn't do anything about it so we never shopped there again.

Another time when we bought a new bigger tent trailer we went to a local campground for a test run and everyone helped set it up. Didn't quite get everything right and Roger fell out in the middle of the night and couldn't figure out how to get back in. Fun, fun, fun.

Probably the most memorable though was when we went around Lake Superior. Went west through the U.P. it was ordinary until we got to Canada. Had friends in Thunder Bay, Ontario so we stopped to see them. They gave us ideas what to visit around there. One was a 2-1/2 mile hike up a “mountain ”. Tim was 2-1/2. I made him hold my hand all the way or we would have lost him. Can you imagine being little and having your arm up all that way up and down?!!!. Poor kid, worried mother! It was worth the hike with spectacular views of Thunder Bay with a replica of a pirate ship. We stayed in a camp ground in the area. During the night a bat got inside and that same worried mother went nuts yelling at Grandpa to get it out, at the kids to stay under the covers so they wouldn't get bit, them wanting to see a bat. The neighbors yelling at us to quiet down. Fun, fun, fun. Grandpa trapped it and put it out. Then on to an amethyst mine where we got to hunt for them or dig for them. Brought back some nice ones. Then continued on to a campground about halfway across the top of the lake. Wow! Lots of big logs on the beach and floating down the lake to a processing place where they were hauled in. Lots on the beach though and lots of signs saying to keep children away from them. Only problem was we didn't see the signs because Steve and Grandpa and I stayed to get the tent-trailer set up and the others went to play. Just about had the trailer complete and the kids came screaming and Rogers head was bleeding. They had of course been playing with the logs,

building a log cabin. Roger and Tim were on the ground M.B. on top ready to push a log off, Roger got hit on the head. A trip to Marathon to get him taken care of with stitches. On the way we passed a car pulled off on the other side of the road with the driver slumped over, like he was sleeping only looking pretty limp. Turned out he was dead. Never found out the whys. We left there the next day. Having a good time, playing along the way. Tim chasing seagulls on the beaches, calling they're his friends. Hiking trails and such. Returning on one trail and almost out with Grandpa and Tim bringing up the rear we stirred up some yellow jackets. Tim and Grandpa got stung, Tim badly. Not knowing about bee stings we laughed and took pictures because Tim was puffed up. That night Roger was not doing well so we called an ER, they said he had a slight concussion and told us what to do. So we did whatever and moved on, Tim seemed ok. Roger was sluggish but ok. We made our way around to WaaWaa and back into the states. They had told us when to have Rogers stitches out. But we didn't find any place til we got to Traverse City. By then we were down to \$20 cash, no cards then. But we were days past time for removal. Insurance was different then too. So we stopped at Munson hospital and told them our dilemma. No problem, they did everything with me watching all the stuff they were using and worrying about costs. Lucky us. They didn't charge us anything! So we still had twenty dollars for gas. Made it home safely. Roger survived and Tim went on

bee sting watch. Never had to carry the “pen” but was always on the watch list.

It was really a great trip in spite of all that happened. For some reason we got a survey from the state about traveling and highways. There were no freeways north of probably 94 then. I told them they needed to be more diligent about the ad signs along the highway as we were short of money and stopped for gas only to find stations permanently closed. That was before signs were limited. Remember this was 50 years ago.





# What was it like learning to drive?



Well the first attempt was in my high school boyfriend's new 1949 Ford whatever. Didn't go well. No accidents, just didn't get it.

We still had the Model A. I was NOT learning in that. I was afraid of damaging it anyway. And if I couldn't manage a '49 , I certainly couldn't get a '31.

Dearborn had a good bus system so between that and friends and family I didn't have a problem getting anywhere.

Grandpa didn't even try. No need. He got me everywhere or I walked. Until Steve. Then there was a real reason. Doctors appointments and such. So I went the route of a driving school. Easy. And our car was a '55 Plymouth convertible, automatic so no shifting involved.

Many years later we got a Toyota Corolla for me to use for errands. Grandpa, the guy with the patience of Job, gave up and it

became his car. We were practically disowned by my Ford family. We drove it to Dearborn one day. My folks, who lived in a 7th floor apartment then, wouldn't even look out the window at it. My nephew, who worked at GM read us the riot act. We were practically disowned. They all got over it eventually.

# Who did you go to prom with?



**E**asy one. Never went to a prom. But no regrets. Have never been very social or felt the need to do things because everyone else did. My high school boyfriend and I were good friends until he died.



# How did you decide to get married?



Sixty or seventy years ago life was very different. We've gone from being clothed from head to foot to wearing practically nothing.

Women then expected to be homemakers. One breadwinner households were the norm. Sex was for husbands and wives. Children out of wedlock was a terrible thing. There have always been `rebels ` of course. But most people got married to live together and have families.

Women had started becoming a larger part of the workforce during WWII and finding out there was more to life than waiting on men. Everything became more expensive so it took two incomes to live comfortably.

After the burn your bra, free love movement people got even more independent. When Steve went off to college in 1976 dorms

were just beginning to be shockingly co-ed and people became freer, until now it's do whatever works for you.

I couldn't begin to think what we would have done if we were young in today's world because my mind is rooted in the mores of the past. I do know if I had a serious friend after Grandpa died I wouldn't bother getting married.

So for us it was either or. So since we decided it was forever, we married. And it worked because we worked at it and respected each other (and Grandpa had the patience of Job).

*Mr. and Mrs. Harry W. Brockmiller, Sr.*

*request the honour of your presence  
at the marriage of their daughter*

*Lou-Ellen Elaine Brockmiller*

*to*

*Mr. Richard B. Ehnis*

*on Saturday, the fourth of August  
nineteen hundred and fifty-six  
at five-thirty o'clock in the afternoon*

*First Methodist Church*

*Mason and Garrison*

*Dearborn, Michigan*





# What fascinated you as a child (or at any time)?



I guess I'm not fascinated by things as much as how's and whys. I can remember my brother sitting and watching ants at work for long periods of time. Not ant farms, real ant hills. He'd sit in a chair, elbows on his knees, chin in hands and just watch. That's not me, I get bored and don't care.

You know, (and we disagree, but that's ok,) my biggest why is why ethnically, people are different.

Why after 20 years in a mental hospital was your great grandmother Ehnis able to remember specific abilities? Like measurements that you normally lose if you don't use them. Fascinated me enough that I considered going back to school to better understand. Didn't of course, life got in the way.

What is the connection that makes one person like another particular person enough to spend their life with as opposed to

some other similar person. You have lots of good friends but there is just one special person.

# What was life like in the 60s?



Obviously very different. And because I was a whole lot younger my view of life was also very different. Once again, that was a LONG time ago in my life.

Think about technology. Computers weren't. TV was mostly 3 networks and black and white. Most women were housewives and mothers. Other than professionals, if they worked it was part time so homelife was more family oriented. Dinner was a family affair.

Life was simpler. Wages and prices were much lower. People were seemingly more trustworthy. Crime was different. Drugs were not rampant.

Kids could play safely outdoors. And were able to go farther afield safely. We played kick the can in the street until the street lights came on. Then everyone went home. When we went to get our friends we stood outside their house and called their name

The way we dressed was different. If I went to the local grocery store 3 blocks away, I had to change from play clothes to a dress. There were no supermarkets. Bread was a nickel a loaf and was mostly Wonder Bread type. (Whoops! Sorry that paragraph the 40's)

By the sixties I was married with kids. We hung our wash out on clothes lines, even if we had dryers. (Why is that first in my mind. We had diaper service or washed them and hung them out and folded.)

Phones were expensive, every call outside of your area was long distance and more expensive. We limited calls to my parents in Dearborn because it was long distance .

Roads were not as busy or as congested and in better shape, with Burma Shave fun signs along the way. Traffic was slower and you could read them. Infrastructure was better maintained.

Life in general was much simpler.

# What is your definition of love?



**D**epends on use.

Love for another person is composed of many things.

Respect for their wellbeing, and their thoughts, are uppermost in my mind. How much you enjoy being with them. Caring how they feel. It takes time to develop.

I'm sure there are different levels of love. One might not love a friend or relative as much as a spouse or child. And love for a child may be different from that of a spouse but you still need the basics.

Lust is not love. It's self gratification. Good to have and enjoy but not necessarily composed of the same thoughts and feelings.

It's said you can't love inanimate things but why not. You can love ice cream. Or a color, or lots of other things. Just means you really, really like them.



# What was something you were surprised to learn when you moved out from your parents' house?



Well you already know I'm wired differently. I was apparently never strongly attached to my family. Never felt strongly about being part of it. It just was the way life was. Was never homesick when I went to camp or college. So leaving was just another move.

I lived at home until I got married. Was planning on getting an apartment with a friend but she got married instead.

I didn't get married to escape a bad home life, it was just another step in life, or moving on. I'm sure my parents loved me but I don't recall them ever telling me so.

So the surprise of moving out I guess was how much more fun life was living with someone who put me first and shared their life with me. And told me every day he loved me no matter what. And how proud he was of what we produced.



# What are your favorite possessions? Why?



Well, I've thought about it all week. The criteria I used was, what would I save if my house were on fire.

That doesn't count for the greatest "possession". Family. And I like them all.

While I really like most of my possessions, the first thing that comes to mind is my acrylic lamp. I've loved it from the moment I first saw it in a shop in Plymouth, probably 30 or more years ago. I was at a conference for work and a few of us browsed shops during lunch break or in the evening. I had ridden from TC with a friend and Steve was picking me up after so I could stay for the weekend. I dragged him to the shop to show it to him and said what a nice Christmas present it would make, from everyone since it was over anyone's budget. And it did. And I still love it.

Another thing would be my fish mirror. Its whimsical.

And my rings for obvious reasons. I didn't want an engagement ring, just a nice wide band wedding ring. But it was important to Grampa to have the diamond. Even though he didn't want a ring because he couldn't wear it while working. He was a tree trimmer at the time.

And my China. I bought it before I even knew Grandpa. I love its simplicity. And it was always great fun when the Hudson's truck would deliver a new piece or two from Aunt Carole and Uncle Bill. She and I had picked out china and silver together. In those days Hudson's delivered in their own trucks from Detroit. Exciting. I'm still not good at using it every day. Don't know what I'm saving it for.

And my Bose radios. Still good.

There are other things of course but those really stand out.



The acrylic lamp



# What is your idea of perfect happiness?



I don't believe there is ever "perfect" anything. There is always a hitch somewhere.

But....

We'll have to go with current time since it's another one of those "depends on " things.

I'm pretty happy most of the time. It could be happier if family were closer and I could spend more time with them on a daily or weekly basis. But that's a choice we made long ago when we were younger and happiness was to move north and our kids were just starting on their adult lives. I wouldn't be happy living where everything is so crowded and hectic.

Maybe it would be some idyllic place on a lake with everyone important to me near by and happy in their lives.

If a healthy Grandpa were here would be good too. He was a lot of fun when he was young and healthy.

I guess happiness is what you make it, different for everyone.

# What were you like when you were 50?



**I**n the prime of life I guess. Working at Lithographics. Most kids were grown but no grandkids yet. Tim was in high school so we were freer to do more traveling. Everyone was in good health. Life was good.

For my 50th birthday the people at work had an office party for me. Had a male “stripper” come in. Embarrassing!!!. I was the old lady not exactly into their young shenanigans, but it was fun.





# What are your favorite musicians, bands or albums?



As you can imagine that has changed over the years but basically the same kinds prevail.

When I was younger it was primarily music of the times, big band, crooners, always classical in the background.

Now I still like all those things and classic rock .

Frank Sinatra was just getting started when I was in the 8th grade and a remains a favorite. Which means I like Michael Buble too. Harry Connick jr, not so much. Nor Tony Bennett.

But I like many from later times too. Probably the same genre though.

And classical. Borodin, Greig, Tchaikovsky (thank heaven I didn't have to spell that), Ravel, all the well knowns.

I used to have records of the Grand Canyon Suite by Ferdie Grofe. And Victory at Sea by ??? someone more current.

But I also like a lot of the older country/western people too.  
I don't like loud noise that some call music.

It seems to me after writing two of these today that I'm not very well defined about anything. Though I'm sure I do have some absolutes about some things.

Maybe I should be in the eclectic pigeon hole, or wishy-washy.

# How has your life turned out differently than you imagined it would?



**I**t's certainly been a lot longer than I expected.

When I graduated high school in 1950 we wondered if we would be here to see the next century. But here we are almost a quarter of the way through it.

My expectations were probably all short term. I would go to school, graduate. Be a lab technician since I couldn't qualify to be an airline hostess or whatever they were called then.

That didn't work out, left school and current boyfriend and got a job where my sister-in-law (aunt Carole) worked at a medical clinic as a secretary in the x-ray department.

Another person I'd known for a long time worked there (Joanne). We became better friends and hung out together. When a new big

hospital (Oakwood, now Beaumont) opened we both went there. She as an x-ray tech, me as secretary to the dietitian.

Life was good but still no big future plans. I was very successful as a secretary. Had good friends but no plans except to get an apartment with Joanne (the pretty, worldly divorcee). I was still the quiet "country bumpkin". But she suddenly decided to get married, so no apartment.

She moved, I continued working, dating, still no real plans or thoughts of the future. Life was good. Then of course everything changed.

Grandpa came into the picture. Still wasn't ready to make future plans.

Of course we did.

But still coasting. Didn't plan on kids, at least for a couple years. But kids had other plans.

Then life just happens and the goal is to raise good kids. We did.

Always in the back of our minds was to move north some day. We tried once but necessities got in the way. Like Roger needed thyroid surgery, my dad got cancer, we still had Grandma Ehnis to take care of, Steve needed a school with a good swim program and good band program, all the little details of life.

Then you're retired. And just enjoy life. And grandkids.

Then you just keep on keepin on.

Never did figure out what I wanted to do when I grow up.

Or maybe I did. And enjoyed it all (well most of it).



# What have you changed your mind about over the years?



**A** great many things I suppose. As you age and are exposed to more of the world and different people it seems you adjust and move on.

Can't think of anything major right now. Maybe I will revisit later.





# Who have been your closest friends throughout the years?



While there aren't many left, there had been an assortment.

Two that are still living are Marlene and Lyle Sylvester.

Lyle and Chuck Bernhardt were friends of my brother and spent a lot of time at our house during high school. Marlene was my brother's girlfriend for a while. That didn't last. I went out with Lyle once or twice but didn't click. Lyle and Marlene did and they are still together. I was maid of honor at their wedding. She was in mine.

Chuck and I dated for a while, I went off to MSC, he joined Ford Motor and met and married my mothers maid of honors daughter. We all remained friends. Chuck's wife died in 1994, he died in probably 2010, still friends.

When we were younger, before kids, 4 or 5 couples always got together for parties. But as kids arrived the distance between

Ann Arbor and Dearborn became too much and we drifted apart for that kind of thing. The rest of them all lived in Dearborn and kept up the group without us. And we did more with Grandpa's friends.

Joanne and Reg Fischer were good friends too. Joanne was the step-daughter of my dad's good friend. So we got acquainted when I was 7 and she 11. Didn't have a lot to do with her then, but was forced to go to her piano recitals! She was really good. We did occasionally go to their house where she and Uncle Bill delighted in putting their cat down the clothes shoot and running to the basement, grabbing it and repeating it.

Anyway we didn't have a lot to do with each other til we ended up working at the same medical center and then Oakwood hospital.

She married Reg, who introduced me to Grandpa.

They both died this year from covid, in a nursing home,  
with dementia.

Grandpa had many good friends but we never stayed real close after everyone started having kids. Cal and MarvaJane Reimold and Milt and Bev Reimold were close . Milt was our household maintenance man for many years. Bob and Barb Preston were long time friends. Barb lived across the street from Grandpa growing up. Her parents were among the many people who kept an eye on him after his mother went in the hospital as his grandmother and grandfather were not so good at it. Grandpa

was living with them when we got married.

Faye and Sid(Guy) Sindlinger moved in across the street from us on Gralake in 1959 or 60. He died in 2001, she's currently in very bad health. Our first three kids were each a month or two apart in age. Then we had Tim, they got a dachshund named Toby who was Tim's good friend. They were a different kind of friends. The neighborly, parental kind but really good friends. Just not socially. Sid was baseball coach for Steve's "little league". Her birthday is the day before mine though 5 or 6 years younger.

Craig and Carole Smith have been good friends since Roger and their oldest son, Brent, were in grade school and cub scouts together. Craig was Roger's baseball coach. Currently, I haven't been able to get in touch with them so I suspect they're having health issues. Today I got a call from Carole. Health issues it was. She had a double bypass and has been recuperating for the past 12 weeks. Doing well now.

Currently Marylou and Al Shilling are good friends and neighbors. They're like another set of children looking after me sort of. But good friends.

Then there is Bob Schlueter. I met him when I interviewed at the Area Agency on Aging. He had started there the week before so we sort of bonded right from the start. So 34 years later, after working together for ten years, we still meet for lunch when he's

on his way to Lansing from Leland. He went from intake person to director of the AAA and is now retired from that and is head of some aging commission for the State.

There are others. My cousin Marylyn became closer when we both became widowed. She many years before me. Although she was several years younger she lost her husband many years before me and was probably the biggest help navigating the loss. We had many good times, especially lunch and margaritas at La Senorita.

And my cousin Evelyn and her husband Malcolm became much closer as we aged. Now she lost Malcolm and I hope I'm helping her through the first year.

# How far back can you trace your family ancestry?



Several generations on both sides.

I of course have a brother, Harry William, Jr. (Christan Lee, (Dustin((Ethan)), (Diana Lynn, who was murdered by her husband)((son Steven)) and Keith Loren (Alexander William ((SimYee)), Angela.

On my mothers side....

My mother was Dorothy Genevieve Jones

She had 7 brothers and one sister, Twila, who died before she was 2.

Brothers: Harold, Ray (who died in his twenties while learning to be a stunt pilot), Cliff, Merle, Don, Melvin and Chet.

Her parents were Cora Belle Parks and William Frederick Jones

Cora had a sister named Della. William had a sister named Sarah and some brothers.

Cora's father was Leander Parks

My father was Harry William Brockmiller Sr.. He had an older sister, Elva Bernice (Thomas Jamison), no kids, and a younger sister, Helen (Lowell Yates), kids David (Ron, and Nancy), and Evelyn (Malcolm Smith ((Janice and Karen)) and Clark .

His father was William August Brockmiller (brothers Emil, Helmuth).

That's as far as I can go in my head.

I have charts and info that go back to the father of a son who was born in 1778. You're welcome to what I have but I don't know how to get it in here.

# Tell me about one of the best days you can remember.



**T**his took a long time to think about. There have been many great days but this one stands out.

In August of 1956 on our honeymoon we were getting desperate to find a motel with a shower. We had been driving all day in our 1955 Plymouth convertible with the top down. We were in the upper peninsula, in a very small town called Paradise, temperatures in the 80's. There were several motels but none advertising showers (remember, 1956, remote U.P.). We were getting desperate and running out of civilization and light. As a last resort we decided to take the next one we came to, shower not. Turned into what we thought was a short drive in the woods to a place called Timberlost. It was 4 miles on a two track. Crazy! When we got there it was wonderful. Right on the Tahquamenom river with individual cabins. No showers though! Bathroom not

even in the cabin. There was a separate community bathhouse! Too late to change our minds so we stayed. It was great, had two rooms, a kitchen and bedroom. Secluded and quiet. Deer came right up to you. There's a picture somewhere of Grandpa with one. We loved it so much we went back the next year for a week. So on this beautiful October day in 1957 we took an Old Town canoe quite a distance UP STREAM to the lower falls. I was pregnant so Grandpa wouldn't let me paddle. It was absolutely beautiful with peak fall colors. We beached the canoe below the falls and wandered around the little island a while. Really enjoyable. Then back to Timberlost.

I don't remember the rest of the trip, seems like my parents were up there too but stayed in a cabin on the Lake Superior shore. On the way home we took one of the last ferries before the Mackinac bridge opened. There are pictures of that too.

I guess if you can remember that, that clearly for 65 years it was really extra special.



# What was the neighborhood you grew up in like?



From ages 4 to 7 was a pretty average neighborhood. Had plenty of kids to play with, grumpy neighbors that didn't like kids. My aunt and uncle lived behind us. We rented a duplex (up and down). Made good friends there, especially my parents. They had bought a house in that neighborhood when they were first married but lost it in the depression. We were a few blocks from the school where there was lots of open land and woods around. My dad walked a lot with his dog and sometimes took me along. We would look for arrowheads. He had a nice collection.

Then they brought the house at 2028 Cornell and were there until a few years after I was married.

It was a good stable family neighborhood. Had plenty of kids our age who became lifelong friends. There was a huge field with a

railroad at the far side. “Stay away from the tracks because of the bums who rode the trains” . Didn’t of course. Had to check out and walk the tracks occasionally. We made a ball diamond and everyone played, boys, girls, good and bad. Just fun. There were good climbing trees that only a few of us climbed.

My dad walked the dogs there and picked wild asparagus and mushrooms. (It was hard to actually buy either after I got married). And crabapples for my mother to make into jelly. We had grapevines in the backyard she made jelly from too and a black walnut tree. Dad ran over them with the car so they were easier to shuck. And during the war we had a big “victory garden” . There was an old chicken coop we played in, climbed on and jumped off of. When we got too old for that my dad turned it into a dog house. He had sprinter spaniels and bred one a couple of times so we got to watch their tails get “trimmed”.

We girls played school a lot. Because the leaders were catholic we used pencils but couldn’t erase. Needed to get it right the first time. And monopoly a lot. Kick the can, in the street til the street lights came on. Jump rope. When I was about 10 I got into a fight with “the boy next door” for hassling us while we jumped. Broke my ankle. More a small fracture that without x-ray was treated as a sprain. Didn’t know it was actually a fracture til I fell down the stairs at Steve’s apartment in my sixties, went to urgent care and it was x-rayed.

School was just a long block away. You knew just about everyone.

Now our field is filled with small factories and buildings. All the houses(5) except one, that faced the field are gone. Our house has been remodeled and a second story added. It's basically the same neighborhood now. School is gone and condos built on the property. Houses updated.



# What were your favorite subjects in high school?



Well I hated history. Now I realize it was the presentation not the subject. It can be really interesting.

The same can be said for English. German was ok, but just something you were forced to take. Would have been the same whatever language you took.

Math and science were good until I took them in the wrong order and was intimidated by upper classmates because I was a junior girl taking senior physics without the proper background. Chemistry was really good though. I also took something called chemical math. It was an extra class in zero hour. Interesting and easy for me. I actually tutored a friend taking it in college.

I also took business classes that were fun because I was good at them and the people taking them were far less intimidating than the college prep people.



# Have you ever won anything?



A few things.

A l o o n g time ago, I won a small radio on some radio station. Don't remember much about it except it was a good small brown radio I had for a really long time.

Spelling bees in grade school. For which we got ice cream bars.



When we first moved to Traverse City I won \$500 worth of merchandise at Younkers. Don't remember what I chose except the laundry hamper I still have.

And, of course, a few small jackpots at the casino.

That's all I can remember (and that took 5 days).

Well, there was more.....

I won your Grandfather! And with him, his children and grands  
and greats too 🙌🙌🙌🙌

And a good long life to enjoy them all.



# If you were to do it over, what would you do differently?



**N**othing major or I wouldn't be me and you wouldn't be you!



But, remember the manners class?

That was to be sure you and Melissa would grow up comfortable and confident in social situations. I never was.

So I guess having more confidence in myself would have been a good change and made a difference in my life. It has still been very good thanks to your grandfather who did a great job covering for me.



# Have you ever given or been the recipient of a random act of kindness?



I'm sure I have both given and received random acts of kindness throughout life.

Can't remember past specific acts of kindness because they are random and without afterthoughts. You just do them because that's who you are and they are needed at the moment.

Recently we did a "food chain" for a neighbor in need. Not a big deal but greatly appreciated.

The same can be said on the receiving side. People just do good things.

I have received free food at drive ins (more than once) when the car before you pays for your purchase, and you do the same for the next car.

My neighbors do good things for me all the time. They recently made sure I was ok when I didn't show up to walk. And today I sold a table on Facebook that someone posted for me because I'm still not good at understanding doing that stuff. Can't think of anything major though I'm sure I should.

# What was it like the first time you quit a job?



**T**he first time was happy/sad time. I had a really great job as secretary to the head dietitian at the newly opened Oakwood hospital in Dearborn. I was there about three years. Made many good friends and learned a great deal about food and the working world.

I left to get married and move to Ann Arbor.

The next time, though, was much more traumatic. The job began with me doing typing at home for a neighbor who owned a business with a partner and eventually talked me into being their receptionist. They saw potential and made me bookkeeper and eventually office manager. But the partner saw naivety too and eventually had me doing his dirty work with the banks, kiting checks and delaying payments to vendors. He also improved my bookkeeping skills though.

The beginning of the end came when he played so many games with his funds he couldn't make payments and we got in a huge knockdown, dragout argument over payroll. I quit.

When I got home and told Grandpa, he said he was fed up with his job, got into an argument and quit that day too! Great! Two people who always talked everything over and took forever to make a decision lost it the same day.

They begged me to come back to work and I did for about a year but it was the same all over again. I was sorry to leave the other partner but left anyway.

We planned on moving the next year anyway and Grandpa had found another, less stressful job. I did too but got fired two weeks before I was going to give notice.

Good timing because I was able to collect unemployment and take my time finding another job. Stayed at that one for ten years before retiring.

# How did you feel when your first child was born?



Well, excited, delighted, pleased. Got everything I ordered. Blue eyes, nice ears. Boy or girl didn't matter.

Grandpas uncle Stub, who had a lot to do with raising him , had died about six weeks before and Aunt Loretta had ask us to move in with her.

Remember, this was 63 years ago. In those days you stayed in the hospital several days. And there were not all the conveniences there are now. No bedside or cell phones, one phone on a corridor.

Grandpa was not good at getting up in the morning and he was a tree trimmer so started work early. So I had to get up, go down the hall and call him to make sure he got up every morning.

When we went home my mother came out to help (?) or just be a Grandma. She and Aunt Loretta got along well, too well, they talked all the time. Even in the morning when I always want

quiet. It was good of her to come but was happy to have her go home too.

It soon got too much for aunt Loretta to have extra people there and her daughter had just had her third child a couple weeks after so we moved to a duplex. Ironically friends were in the downstairs and had their first child about six weeks after us so we had neighbors in the same situation as us. Worked out well as there was always a baby sitter around.

It was fun watching him grow and do new things. I still remember him walking down the sidewalk in jeans and red hooded sweatshirt touching trees and learning different textures.

When he was eighteen months we bought our first house and Grandpa became a 7up truck owner and salesman. Exciting times.







# What advice would you give your great grandchildren?



**T**here's not much I can contribute to my great grandchildren that would be useful to them. Their world will be drastically different from any experience I have had. Just do your best, treat people how you want to be treated and enjoy whatever you choose to do.

To their parents, however.....

ENJOY them. They come to you with their brain already wired for something. Your job is to help them find whatever that is. And help them learn how to live in their world.



# What are your favorite books?



Sorry I've delayed so long thinking about this one. I still don't have a real answer. I don't read like you do. I read to pass time which I didn't do when I was younger when real life got in the way. Don't know that I've ever read a book twice except by mistake.

There are authors I like, but not meaningful ones. I've learned a lot of interesting things that didn't register when I was in school. I hated history, but presented in story form it really is interesting and encourages learning more about reality, rather than what makes a good story.



# Did you get along with your siblings as a child?



Pretty much. There are only the two of us and only 20 months apart and being a boy and a girl not really any sibling rivalry. Though I still feel he was the favorite child. He's always looked after me though. When I told him this question today he said: and we're still talking.





# What is one of your favorite trips that you've taken? What made it great?



**H**ow about three trips far apart in time?

In 1967 my dad had a heart attack while in California on a cross country trip with my mother. They spent some time there recovering in a hospital of a religious sect I don't recall. Maybe Seventh Day Advent(?). They took really good care of them both. They were traveling in their first converted Ford van. Very primitive by today's standards. When Dad had recovered enough to travel, but not enough to drive they asked if we could meet them in Las Vegas to help my mother drive the rest of the way home. We left Margaret Beth and Roger at my brother's and flew with Steve to Las Vegas to meet them.

I don't remember how long it took us to get home, but it was a great trip. My dad liked to travel and show people new things. While we were in Vegas he took us to casinos where we had great buffet meals for very little money, played slots for real silver dollars while 9 year old Steve waited outside, and just took in all the glitter. It was much more interesting and fun than what casinos and Vegas are today.

This next part will be out of order because I don't remember the exact itinerary.

We went to Kingman, Arizona to meet his cousin and see that area, the Grand Canyon, the Petrified Forest, places with ancient Indian carvings. Anyplace he thought would be interesting we would stop. We planned on going back that way once Roger got old enough to not run over the edge of a cliff. That never happened (well he did get old enough we just never got back until every one was grown up) and the closest we got was a trip to the black hills of South Dakota.

Stayed in motels along the way because the van only slept two.

It was great because we got to see things from a different perspective than if we were parents looking after kids instead of as adult kids learning from older, more experienced parents.

Another really good trip was one we went on with the Nomads. The Nomads was a travel group that owned its own plane, a

Boeing 727 200 with 3 engines in the tail. The same plane as Airforce1 at the time. There were members all across the country. Every month you got a catalog of trips, picked ones you wanted to do, paid your fees. Met and boarded at their Metro hangar and away you went. Customs would come right to our terminal when we returned if necessary. I don't remember what year but we were living in Traverse City so it was probably late 80's or early 90's.

This one took us to St. Thomas in the Virgin Islands where we boarded catamarans, six to a boat with a captain and first mate, ours was a really nice couple from South Africa. Then we spent a week traveling around the area where ever we chose or the captain suggested.

Being claustrophobic I couldn't adjust to the cabin so slept on the deck as did the husband of another couple.

It was great. The captain and mate did everything including really good meals, suggested land opportunities with locals or just sailed. Grandpa and a couple others did a lot of snorkeling. I couldn't master snorkeling but enjoyed the water. One time when we did a shore excursion I didn't quite make the transfer from the dinghy to the cat and gave everyone a good laugh while I got an unplanned swim.

It was a fabulous trip we wanted to do again but never did. It was someplace we would never have gone on our own.



### Virgin Islands

How about one more?

When I was about to retire in 1997 we got an invitation from one of our board members to join a group tour to Kenya in the Fall. Our only other out of the country trip.

We left from Frankenmuth, flew commercial out of Metro to Amsterdam, then on to Kenya. It was a great trip into a really different world.

Our first surprise was when we arrived in Nairobi and deplaned. The airport was heavily armed with guards and heavy all carrying machine guns. And all the protection where ever we went. One woman and her mother were accosted going by themselves to a store a block away from the hotel. Weren't hurt but scared. The traffic was chaotic with only horns and no stop signs or lights. Not many accidents though.

After a day or so in Nairobi we went on safari. Very interesting to see a really primitive country with roads that aren't really roads and people who run everywhere because there's no

transportation outside of the big cities. And I don't recall any other large city. It's no wonder they consistently win marathons. And really wild animals in the wild. We stayed in a "motel" in treetops that you were escorted to from the vehicles with armed guards. And on the ground motels with armed guards to escort you from your individual huts to main buildings because animals wander about. We saw herds of wildebeest, flocks of flamingos, hippos wallowing in rivers, lions just lazing around. Giraffes, elephants wandering around. Nothing really bothered us unless you got aggressive. It was a really great experience. Towns would be in the middle of nowhere with only a few very primitive buildings.

Every now and then we would come upon a little "tourist trap" to shop. But the merchandise was all locally made from local materials. We brought back carved animals for everyone. They weren't real happy if you didn't purchase something. Many of our group were seasoned travelers who bought and shipped stuff, which in spite of how primitive the land, they were able to do. Merchandising! Its everywhere.

It was a really great experience to see how less affluent people live.



## Did you ever move as a child? What was that experience like?



We moved twice when I was a child. The first time I was only 3 or 4 years old and don't remember it or much about that house except for pictures and what I've been told. I know where it was and remember my mother and brother being quarantined because they had scarlet fever. Don't know what my dad and I did during the quarantine. That house was very close to my great-grandmothers and two other houses my great-grandfather built, and two of my dad's uncles. Dearborn was a small town then.

The second time I was just 7, and in the middle of the second grade. I remember that because we were just starting to learn cursive writing in Edison school and Oxford school was way ahead with it. I had a really hard time catching up.

Don't remember anything about the actual move. We had been renting our house on Francis street. My parents bought the house at 2028 Cornell and lived there until about 3 years after I got married.



# Who are your favorite artists?



**I**'ve thought about this way longer than I should. I guess I'm not really into artists. I do really like Monet though.



# What was your first date like with your spouse?



I've told you how we happened to get together.

I met him at Fischers in Port Huron where they were living shortly after they were married, how he was attracted to me but not the other way around since the bunch of guys that were also visiting that weekend were drunk most of the time. But when Fischer's moved back down to the Ann Arbor area we kept being at the same parties. I avoided him as much as I could. Especially after he totaled his new blue 1953 Plymouth convertible (because of drinking). But everyone knew he was interested so I was off limits to his friends. Turned out to be a good thing because they were all worse drinkers than him and most of their marriages didn't last. But I digress...

I would go to Fischer's house for weekends but never til Saturday because the guys went drinking at the VFW on Friday nights. One time I went out on Friday and up til recently thought we just

went out because I was there. This summer their daughter told me it was a setup blind date because Joanne wanted us to get together. I was pretty annoyed when I heard that, but too late, she had died by then and it really worked out anyway because Grandpa was a far better person than her husband or any of the other guys.

Anyway that was the first date, a lovely drunken evening with someone I didn't want to be with.

Don't recall "dates" per se for a long while after that. We just all went partying together until...I don't recall. I guess we must have gone somewhere alone. Then he started asking to get married and I kept saying no.

As with many things, he set a goal and achieved it! Seems to have worked well. We had a much better marriage than any of those friends.

After we decided it was a good idea, we disagreed on getting a ring. I didn't want an engagement ring, just a plain band. That didn't work for him so he went ahead and ordered what he wanted before we told anyone. But....

Before he could give it to me he was felled by a tree and was in the hospital for a while. He was a tree trimmer at the time. So no one knew for a while.

So you asked...

How was he injured.

He was clearing branches at a large busy site and didn't hear "timber", a large tree came down behind him, bounced and smacked him across the back. Broke his collarbone and damaged his back some but fortunately didn't break it.

Shortly after he got out of the hospital I got the ring, made the announcement and we were married a few months later and lived happily ever after.

This all took about two and a half years.



# What is your best relationship advice?



**I** don't have much.

It seems to me that with e-v-e-r-y-t-h-i-n-g in life being so different from the world I grew up in the only thing is respect and honesty.

You, of course, have to have like interests and principles but if you don't respect each other, a relationship just won't last.





# How do you like to spend a lazy day?



Just like I'm doing today (January 5, 2022) cleaning up odds and ends I've neglected. After my morning walk the weather became miserable which means I don't have to do anything (that's a rule as you age 😊)

Paying bills, texting your mother to see how they're doing with covid, taking a nap or two. If I remember, watching a basketball game tonight. Reading a book. Eating junk food for no good reason. Then thinking how stupid that was. So maybe I'll skip that and get homemade soup out of the freezer. Maybe call someone I've put off because I hate making phone calls.

If I get bored enough maybe I'll clean!!! (Probably not going to get THAT bored though)

So I guess there is no one particular thing, just whatever. I have a LOT of lazy days. So when you're ready to retire (seems a long way off now but it isn't really) stay healthy, have plans, hobbies,

more places to travel.

See, here it is, the day is half gone and I'm still working on what to do.

Life at almost 90! FYI...my birthday is 2/2/22! Fun 🎵😊🎵

# What is one of the most difficult things you've ever done? What was the outcome?



After spending three weeks thinking about this there's only one answer I can think of. There are probably more that were important at their time, but none I can recall being more significant.

I've already told you how reluctant I was to commit to marriage. Just wasn't sure for many reasons. I had planned on tall, it's what I knew. Men were supposed to be tall in my mind. My dad was tall, all the influential men in my life were tall. Education was another issue. Grandpa barely getting through high school, me with two years of college. Both issues solved. Height just doesn't matter. You can work around education, learn, compromise if you care enough. And there is more to life than

book learning. Sometimes you just need a reason to learn and a chance for more.

When Grampa was downed by the tree we had already decided to marry but hadn't told anyone yet. He wanted me to have an engagement ring first. (I didn't want one, just a wide band. But he always won.)

At first he was thought to have a broken back along with a broken clavicle. Thus the difficult decision (his and mine). What would that mean for the future? Would he be incapacitated? How would he feel about that? He was a firm believer that husbands were the providers. Never wanted me to work. Would he be able to provide, or be an invalid? Did I want to commit to life with an invalid?

Fortunately the decisions never had to made. Back wasn't broken, only slightly damaged. He recovered, already had the ring, made the announcement and the rest is history.

And obviously it worked. Look at all the wonderful results so far...and more to come 😊. He was so proud.

# How did your parents pick your name?



I don't really know a lot. The Lou part was from a neighbor, Louise Solinger (maybe 2 l's ), a good friend. Have no idea where Ellen or Elaine came from. Haven't seen either one in any in any historical papers.

My first birth certificate came as Llwellyn. A home birth, family doctor (really, my dad's brother-in-law, Aunt Helen's husband). Or maybe the "midwife" didn't ask for spelling.

May have been a difficult birth as they told her no more children, she wanted more, and they had more to think about than spelling. I always understood not having more kids was because her blood type was the universal O. Not sure what O had to do with it but that was a long time ago. And don't remember the O+ or -. One was ok, the other was not.

Who knows. You never ask the right questions at the right time. Or maybe I did and don't remember.



# What makes you happy?



The sunshine, blue sky, happy people, children and grandchildren and greats. Good health, good friends. Being able to spend time with them would be good. Maybe soon. Knowing people care. Being independent and able to drive and take care of myself. Being useful one way or another.

I'm basically a happy person so lots of little things. Changes as you age I think.





# What qualities do you most value in your friends?



**I**ntegrity. Honesty. Openness. Positiveness. Enthusiasm.

Every friend doesn't/hasn't always met that criteria and maybe I haven't either. We all need a little room. But if I ask for an opinion I'd rather have an honest one than a wishy-washy one that's not helpful.

I do have friends I'm not particularly fond of but I see them as needy and maybe I can help a little. Maybe they see me that way too.



# If you could see into the future, what would you want to find out?



**I**t would be fun to know what the world in general will be like in another 50 or 100 years. There has been so much dramatic change in the last hundred years in dress, mores, how we interact with other ethnicities, technology, it's hard to imagine what more can change. We've gone from horse and wagon to vehicles that drive themselves, difficult cross country treks to outer space travel, clothed so completely that no skin shows to practically no clothes. Will we become "the Jetsons"?

Then there is the personal side of things. Does Melissa get a successful business going and become the successful entrepreneur? Does Alex become a successful doctor of one sort or another, able to indulge his passion for expensive cars? What do Addie and Xander and his sister grow up to be? Do you end up with a zillion kids ? Does your mother end up with her house on

the lake? Does Roger get his cabin in the mountains and travel?  
Do uncle Bill and I live to be 100?

So many things I'll never know. Are we reunited with our loved ones after death? Or are we reincarnated as someone/something else? Do we live again as someone else but share that life with the same people ? Was I destined to be with Grandpa because we were together in a previous life?

There are just way too many things things to wonder about!! And yet, if what we think we know about people centuries ago is right, how little PEOPLE have actually changed.

## What are some of your family traditions?



I'm not sure we have any lasting traditions. When I was a child Thanksgiving was when we always had family dinners at my dad's uncle's house. There would be my great-grandmother, my grandfather and his two brothers and all their families. As we got older and their mother passed, the three brothers broke into their own family groups and grew apart. Then we started having Thanksgiving at my grandparents home. And so it goes as each generation passes.

Christmas was always at my mother's parents home. They had seven surviving children when I was a child, having lost a daughter as an infant and a son in his twenties. So there were always lots of kids and grandkids. Grandma always did a grab bag for the grandkids, cartons of cigarettes for the men and nylons for the women. Just some simple gifts, and dinner.

When my family was young it changed but we still got together, usually at our house because we had more, younger kids and my brothers family celebrated on Christmas eve with their family.

But still had a family gathering. As our kids got older it split again. We're probably on the verge of the next split as times and families change.

Can't think of any other real traditions. Only a few names have been passed down. Oh yes, there is the "29" cup.

# If you could thank anyone, who would you thank and why?



Well there's plenty of people along the way to thank for something significant. But you can't do everyone or the page would never end.

Currently I have some of the best neighbors you could ask for. This morning, at 6:30, my driveway was being cleared by an 82 year old man who gets up really early and needs something to do. Then he goes on down the street doing more, then walks his dog a mile. So thanks to him.

Two weeks ago other neighbors had a fun birthday dinner party for me in lieu of family not being available for one reason or another. And they made 6 "meals on wheels" for later. They also clear my snow and make sure I'm ok, and thanks to them.

It's just a really nice neighborhood. But we've had good friends and neighbors all along the way, each contributing appropriately

for the age, at the time.

When we were young and starting out there were plenty of helpful people. From the folks keeping an eye on Grandpa to the people making sure we got good jobs and mortgages we could afford. And neighborly help when we needed it.

And again in middle age the appropriate good deeds were done. Couldn't possibly thank all those people enough except to return the favors or "pay it forward " to others.

Besides those thanks there are all the personal thanks too. To the parents for giving a proper upbringing despite all the complaints. And the kids and grandkids for turning out so well. And the "greats" for just being.

The biggest thanks though have to go to my ever-patient husband who put up with a spoiled, bossy know-it-all those years. HIS final conversation was thanks for the good life we shared for 52+ years.



# Do you prefer summer or winter?



If I had to choose between those two summer would be the answer because, enjoyable as winter can be, driving has always been unlikable. Not only my driving but worrying about everyone else.

However, spring is even better. Everything is fresh and new. Flowers are blooming, trees are budding and birds are singing. People are happier.



# How has the country changed during your lifetime?



Well, since I live in my small warped world, not a whole lot. We've all gotten older and wiser? but still live in our own little world.

And I'm not sure the country has really changed either. Yes, some areas, like transportation, electronics and space exploration have made drastic changes but they are just progress and progress has been happening forever. We've added a couple states. When I was young there were only 48 states.

However, there are still people and politics. And it seems to me that people have changed from simple, honest people who care about the country and each other, to people who care more about themselves. From top to bottom, richest to poorest. It seems to be all about "me".

Maybe it's always been that way since the pilgrims were thinking about themselves when they came here and essentially took over someone else's land.

I'm sure progress will continue until, by the time Xander and my great granddaughter are my age, this age will seem archaic. Or maybe we'll have blown earth into little pieces, or the oceans will have taken over so much land that there's only the central states left. But let's not be so pessimistic, maybe all the changes will be good, everyone will be of mixed race with no more ethnic clashes and peace will prevail.

# What are your favorite plays?



Not sure exactly what you mean. I don't know any classical plays. Our high school curriculum wasn't that extensive 75 years ago. (Alex can give a synopsis of many). Our Town was probably the only play we really looked at. Or maybe I just wasn't on that track. I was put in the non-college bound track and played catch up to get what was essential for college.

In my adult life Phantom of the Opera is probably the only real play I've seen (several times). The only others I enjoyed were non-classics.

Before Grandpa, Bill and I were more into symphonies, travelogues and theater organs concerts in downtown Detroit with our friends.

